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The 2 French Future Tenses – Futur Proche Vs Futur Simple

Using the futur proche is more and more common in spoken French to describe events taking place in a more or less near future.

Unlike English, the use of futur proche in French reinforces the idea that the speaker believes the action will become real.

A – Future And Near Future Are Not Used The Same Way In French And English

Let's take an example:

- Je suis enceinte. Dans neuf mois, je vais avoir un enfant.
  I'm pregnant. In nine months, I..... have a child.

In French, we would use "I'm going to have a child" in this context. Not so much because it's in the "near" future – 9 months isn't a really short time – but rather because it's an upcoming change, something that we are almost certain is going to happen.

In English, it's more likely that you would say: "I will have a child" here. It makes it more real: it will happen = it's almost a sure thing.

B – Upcoming Change Versus Consequences Of The Change

In French, the futur proche is used for an upcoming change.
The futur simple tends to be used for the consequences of this change.

- Dans neuf mois je vais avoir un enfant : je travaillerai à mi-temps et je devrai trouver une garde d'enfant.
  In nine month I'm going to (if I go for a literal translation... but as I said above, will may be more appropriate here) have a child: I will work part time and I will have to find a nanny.
  Note that you could also say "je vais travailler à mi-temps et je vais devoir..." Nothing wrong with this either.

Futur Simple Is Not Very Used In French

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2. Big picture/grandiose plans with "quand":
Quand je serai grand, je serai président = When I grow up, I will be president.

3. Things that you seriously plan to do in the future, and are doable, but that are not necessarily in the process of happening.
Un jour, j'aurai des enfants = one day, I'll have kids.

Otherwise we mostly use the futur proche, which is great news for students of French since the futur proche is so easy to use!

Future Tense Or Present Tense In French?

Sometimes in spoken French, just like in English, if the future event is really close in time, we could even use the present tense.

- Tu finis à quelle heure ce soir ? = at what time do you end your day tonight?

In a more formal language, we would say "at what time will you/are you going to end your day tonight?"

French Future Tense Or Conditional?

In modern French, the "je" form of a verb sounds exactly the same in le futur simple and the present conditional (the final S being silent).

1. Je mangerai – future

2. Je mangerais – conditional

I just learned that traditionally, the "je" form of the future should have a "ré" sound and the conditional a "rè" sound. This was news to me, and I was baffled!! But most people agree that nowadays, they sound the same: see the discussion of wordreference.

So how do you know the difference? Well, either you translate in English – which for once is going to be useful… The future uses "will", the conditional "would".

As for the French, our trick is to change the person: "je" sounds the same, but not "tu" (tu mangeras ≠ tu mangerais) So we switch to "tu" to know how to spell the verb…

However, many French people make that mistake in writing: using the conditional is so much common than the simple future that writing "mangerais" when "mangerai" is needed is a super widespread typo… I often fall in that trap!

Practice Does It

There is a huge difference between passing a French written test and being able to speak French… Understanding the logic and knowing the verb forms is enough for the written test.

When you speak however, you need to know the right French pronunciation, with the liaisons and silent letters, and the verb form has to come fast. The only way to achieve that is to work with audio, even for your French verb conjugations!